

B2B SALES ESSENTIALS

B2B Sales Essentials — Level 1 — Day 2: Reaching the Right Person: Outreach and the First Conversation

Study guide · Self-study

Level 1 · Day 2: Reaching the Right Person: Outreach and the First Conversation

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 2 of the Level 1 self-study series. You work alone, at your own pace, in your first weeks of selling to businesses. Read a section, then stop and do the short reflection before moving on. The exercises ask you to write and speak, not just read.

Keep the examples in this guide in mind, but do not copy them word for word. Your opening should sound like you. Write your answers in the What Would You Say? section before you look at the model answers. The model answers are examples, not scripts.

You will use this guide to plan and run real outreach: research a target business, find the right person inside it, write a short message that earns a reply, handle an early brush-off calmly, and open a first conversation that ends with a next step.

> **NOTES**
>
> Read the buyer psychology sections slowly. They explain why clients react the way they do, and that understanding does more for your results than any script.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: Understand why a business contact decides in the first seconds whether to keep listening, and how pressure, tone and relevance shape that decision.

Attitude: Treat early brush-offs as reflexes, not verdicts, and stay calm and useful whether the person says yes or no.

Skill: Find the right contact in a target business, send one relevant outreach message, and open a first conversation that ends with a specific next step.

Upskill: Handle a repeated brush-off or a clear refusal with a respectful exit, and log the outcome accurately, including any request not to be contacted again.

Reaching the Right Person

Day 1 taught you to research a business and build a reason to reach out. Today you use that reason to contact a human being. The first job is finding the right person inside the business, because a great message sent to the wrong person wastes both of your time.

In most companies, the person who uses what you sell is not the person who buys it. A facilities manager feels the problem daily. A finance lead controls the budget. An operations director often owns the decision. Your research from Day 1 should tell you which role feels the pain your offer addresses.

Start with one hypothesis. Write down the role you believe owns the problem, and one sentence on why. Then test it. In a small business, the owner may be the only contact you need. In a larger one, look for a role title that matches the problem, such as operations, procurement, or a department head.

Why this works: a message that names a real business issue in the contact's own area gets read, because it answers their first silent question: is this relevant to me? A generic pitch to a random inbox gets deleted, because it answers nothing.

Common mistake: contacting the first email you find, then blaming the offer when nobody replies. Fix: spend five minutes confirming that this role actually owns the problem. If you cannot explain in one sentence why this person cares, you are not ready to write.

Practice example: You sell scheduling software to clinics. Your research shows a 40-person clinic with two locations and a reception team that books by phone. You decide the practice manager likely owns the problem. You check the clinic's website, find the role listed, and write your hypothesis: "The practice manager feels the booking delays because her reception team handles every call manually."

First Contact: What Happens in the First Seconds

Every first contact, whether email, phone or a message, gives the other person a fast judgment to make. In his book Thinking, Fast and Slow, Daniel Kahneman describes fast thinking and deliberate thinking. Fast thinking is automatic and effortless. Deliberate thinking takes real effort and only engages when a decision needs it.

When your message or call arrives, the person makes a fast judgment long before they weigh any detail: is this safe, is this relevant, do I want to continue? That judgment happens before they read your second sentence or hear your full introduction. In practice, your opening either answers those questions or it does not.

The First-Contact Standard (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Kahneman, Brehm and Guyer et al.) gives you four behaviors, used in this order. Low Threat: say who you are and what company you represent, calmly and at a natural pace. Autonomy: give an easy way to decline. Relevance: give one true reason this contact is about them. Curiosity: ask one easy, open question.

Why this works: people answer a message that feels safe and clearly about them. When they can leave easily, staying feels like their choice, and a chosen conversation is worth more than a captured one.

Common mistake: stacking three reasons and two questions into one message to "save time." Fix: one reason, one question.

> **NOTES**
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> Your goal on first contact is a reply or a conversation, not a sale. A small yes is enough.

Why Pressure Backfires: Autonomy and Reactance

Psychologist Jack Brehm described how people react when they feel their freedom to choose is threatened. They push back to restore it, sometimes wanting the restricted option more than before, just because it was restricted. The effect is stronger when the language sounds controlling: "you must," "you need to," "this is your last chance."

Business buyers feel this too. A message that corners them ("I just need fifteen minutes of your time") turns the exchange into a contest. Instead of judging your offer, they spend their attention resisting you. The pressure creates the resistance, and then the seller misreads that resistance as "no interest."

The First-Contact Standard's Autonomy step exists for this reason. You give a clear, easy way to decline: "If this isn't a priority right now, just tell me and I'll stop." Then you mean it. A person who feels free to say no is much more likely to keep talking, because the conversation stops being a threat to their control.

Common mistake: saying "no pressure" while your voice, your follow-ups and your urgency all signal pressure. Fix: make the freedom real. When the person declines, accept it in one calm sentence and close.

Your Voice and the Impression It Leaves

Separate from your words, the person hears how you sound. Research on voice and persuasion, such as Guyer, Fabrigar and Vaughan-Johnston's 2019 work, suggests that listeners read confidence from steadiness and fluency: a natural pace, steady intonation, few hesitations. A rising pitch at the end of every sentence sounds like you are asking permission.

One popular myth says you should slow down and lower your voice to sound credible. The research does not support that as a rule. What comes across is composure, not slowness. Very slow speech can sound hesitant, and a performed "deep radio voice" can sound fake. Sound like the most composed version of yourself.

In B2B this matters because your contact is judging whether you sound like a professional peer or like someone selling at them. A buyer who hears rushing and over-explaining assumes you need the deal badly, and may test that by pushing on price later.

Practical step: record your opener on your phone and listen for three things: hesitation, rushing, and over-explaining. Then record it again, a little steadier. Repeat until it sounds like a calm colleague.

> **NOTES**
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> Statements should end as statements. Save the questioning tone for real questions.

The Pressure You Can Hear: Rushing, Over-Explaining, Conceding

When you need an outcome too much, it leaks into your behavior. You rush your words. You explain more than needed to justify yourself. You bring forced enthusiasm. You offer something away early, like a discount before anyone asked. You struggle to let a first "no" stand without pushing past it.

People cannot always name what they hear, but they sense the pressure and get more cautious. The opposite is staying calm and useful whether the person says yes or no. That is not indifference to the client; it is indifference to the pressure of the moment.

A simple self-test before any first call: if this person says no, can you say "No problem, thanks for your time" and mean it? If the honest answer is no, your voice will probably show it. Take a moment to reset first. A slow breath out before you dial helps more than a last-minute script.

Common mistake: rescuing a lukewarm conversation by offering a concession. Fix: never offer a discount to save a first conversation. If the topic comes up, answer honestly and keep it short; terms belong in a later conversation, which you will cover on Day 4.

The Opener: Earn Attention Instead of Demanding It

An opener works when it is a relevant departure from what the person expects. Most buyers receive a steady stream of generic messages: "Can I tell you about our services?" or "Are you still interested?" A specific, honest opening gets attention back, because it is clearly about the person's actual situation.

The rule is strict: different is only useful when it is also relevant. A message that references their business issue and asks one easy question beats a clever line every time. Never fake a connection, never imply you know them when you do not, and never invent urgency. Buyers notice, and trust is much harder to rebuild than to earn.

Compare these openers:

- Generic: "Can I tell you about our services?"
- Relevant: "I'm (your name) from (your company). If this isn't a priority for you, tell me and I'll stop. I noticed your team is opening a second location. What's the biggest headache in running two booking teams?"
- The second version says who you are, gives an easy exit, offers one true reason, and asks one open question. It follows the four behaviors of the First-Contact Standard in order.
- Why this works: the buyer's fast judgment lands on "safe, relevant, easy to answer," so they reply instead of deleting.

> **NOTES**
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> One reason, one question, one short message. If you cannot find a true, specific reason, wait until you have one.

Handle Early Brush-Offs Calmly

"I'm busy." "Send me an email." "We're all set." These are often reflexes, given to end an unexpected interruption before the person has evaluated anything. They are not the same as a clear decision like "we're not interested, please don't call again."

Treat a reflex as information, not a verdict. One calm, low-pressure response is allowed: "Of course, I caught you in the middle of something. I'll come back at a better time: is next week or the week after easier?" That answer acknowledges the interruption, offers a real choice, and asks for one small step. It is the kind of question you will build in the last section.

If the person repeats the brush-off, or gives a clear refusal, treat it as a genuine no. Thank them, end the call respectfully, and log the request, including any do-not-contact instruction, exactly as your company's rules require.

Why this works: your calm handling of a brush-off proves the low-pressure opening was real. That is what keeps a door open for a later conversation, sometimes months later.

Common mistake: pushing past a repeated brush-off because "they just haven't seen the value yet." Fix: the first brush-off earns one gentle pivot if it sounds like a reflex; a repeated one or a clear refusal ends the call.

A Simple Structure for the First Conversation

Now put it together into a short first conversation. You are not pitching. You are earning a next step.

Open with the First-Contact Standard in order: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity. Then listen more than you talk. Ask about the contact's situation and what is coming up for them. When you hear something interesting, reflect it back in their own words. This is also where you will go deeper; discovery gets its own full treatment on Day 3.

Close the conversation with one specific next step, agreed in plain words. Never end with "I'll follow up" and no date. Use an open what or how question, or a real choice with a date: "What would help you most: a short call on the 12th with your operations lead, or a one-page summary emailed by Friday?" A yes/no close, like "Shall I send you a calendar invite?" is the weak version; it makes the decision feel like a trap and invites a polite no.

Why this works: a specific, easy next step is a small commitment. Small commitments are easier to agree to than big ones, and each one moves the decision forward. Pushing for a big commitment early creates resistance instead.

> **NOTES**
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> End every first conversation with a date, a person and a specific action. If the person will not commit to any next step, that is useful information, not a failure.

Apply It in Your Role

Inside Sales: Write your first message using the four behaviors in order. Keep it to a few sentences: who you are, an easy exit, one true reason, one open question. Record your opener out loud and fix any rushing.

Outside Sales: Before you visit a site, confirm the right contact by role. Plan your first sentence and your exit line word for word, then say them calmly.

Team support: Ask to shadow one call made by an experienced colleague this week. Listen for the four behaviors, and note where the call ended with a specific next step.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you check the model answers at the end. Keep each answer to one or two sentences.

1. Your research shows a target business is opening a second branch. You have not confirmed who owns scheduling there. What do you write in your first message?

2. On a call, the contact says "I'm in the middle of something, can you email me?" in a rushed voice. What do you say next?

3. You send a message to a contact who turns out to be the wrong role: they reply "I don't handle this." What do you do?

4. On a first call, you ask a good question and the contact goes quiet for a few seconds. What do you do?

5. The conversation is going well. How do you end it, and what exactly do you say?

Key Takeaways

- Find the role that owns the problem before you write; if you cannot say in one sentence why this person cares, you are not ready.
- In the first seconds the contact judges whether this is safe, relevant and worth continuing; your opening answers those questions or it fails.
- Pressure creates resistance. Give a real, easy way to decline, and mean it when they decline.
- Steady and natural delivery beats slow and deep. Record your opener and listen for hesitation, rushing and over-explaining.
- When you need the outcome too much, it shows in your voice and your early concessions. Reset your breathing before the call.
- An opener earns attention only when it is different and relevant. One true reason and one open question beat clever lines.
- A first brush-off is usually a reflex. You may make one calm, low-pressure response. A repeated brush-off or a clear refusal is a real no: exit respectfully and log it.
- End with a specific next step agreed with a date, using a calibrated question or a real choice, never a yes/no close.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Choose one option per question.

1. A client opens your email. According to the fast and deliberate thinking model, what happens first?

A. They carefully compare your offer with two competitors.

B. They make a quick judgment about whether the message is worth their attention.

C. They calculate the cost of your service in detail.

D. They forward it to their finance team for review.

2. You are about to write "I just need ten minutes of your time" to a busy operations lead. What is the best revision based on what you know about autonomy?

   A. "I only need five minutes, I promise."

   B. "You must see this before your second branch opens."

   C. "I'm (your name) from (your company). If scheduling across two sites isn't a priority, tell me and I'll stop."

   D. "This is your last chance to fix scheduling before the opening."

3. A contact says "I'm busy" in a rushed voice, five seconds into your call. What is the best next move?

   A. Keep talking so they hear your full reason for calling.

   B. Offer a discount to earn a few more minutes.

   C. Acknowledge the interruption, offer a real choice of times, and ask for one small step.

   D. Call back three times today until they listen.

4. Your recorded opener sounds slow, with long pauses and a rising pitch at the end of every sentence. What should you change?

   A. Nothing; slow and low is always the most credible.

   B. Speak more steadily and naturally, and let statements end as statements.

   C. Speak faster and louder to sound energetic.

   D. Add more detail so the length matches the pauses.

5. A first conversation has gone well. Which ending fits what you practiced today?

   A. "Shall I send over a proposal?"

   B. "Would you like to sign up?"

   C. "I'll follow up soon."

   D. "What would help you most: a short call on the 12th with your operations lead, or a one-page summary by Friday?"

Upskill Challenge

Before Day 3, complete these steps on the job.

- ☐ Pick one target business from your Day 1 research and write a one-sentence hypothesis naming the role you believe owns the problem and why.
- ☐ Write your first outreach message using the four behaviors in order: who you are, an easy exit, one true reason, one open question.
- ☐ Record your opener out loud and listen once for hesitation, rushing and over-explaining. Record it again, steadier.

☐ Send the message, or, if you are not yet contacting clients yourself, shadow an experienced colleague making a similar first contact.

☐ Handle any reply calmly. Practice one gentle response to a reflex brush-off, and respect a repeated brush-off or clear refusal.

☐ Log the outcome by stage reached, the type of reply, and the next step with a date, including any request not to be contacted again.

Then answer for yourself: which part felt weakest (finding the contact, the message, the voice, the brush-off or the next step), and what will you change on your next attempt?

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Keep the principle; use your own words.

1. "I'm (your name) from (your company). If this isn't on your radar, tell me and I'll stop. I saw you're opening a second location. What's the biggest headache in running two booking teams?" Why it works: it follows the four behaviors in order, gives one true reason, and asks one easy question, so the contact can reply in their own words.

2. "Of course, I caught you mid-task. I'll come back at a better time: is next week or the week after easier?" Why it works: it acknowledges the interruption, offers a real choice of times, and avoids pressure.

3. "Thanks for telling me, that saves us both time. Who owns scheduling for the two sites?" Why it works: it treats the reply as useful information, stays calm, and asks one easy question that moves you to the right person.

4. Say nothing for those few seconds. Let the contact fill the silence. If they do not, ask one simple follow-up. Why it works: the urge to fill silence usually makes you answer your own question for them, which narrows the answer you get. The full discovery sequence comes on Day 3, where you will build on this pause.

5. "What would help you most: a short call on the 12th with your operations lead, or a one-page summary by Friday?" Why it works: it ends with a real choice and a date, so the contact decides how to move forward, which is easier to agree to than a yes/no question.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. The first judgment is fast and automatic; relevance, safety and worth are decided before any details are weighed.
- 2. C. Leading with a need you have from the client threatens their freedom to choose, and the fixed time demand invites resistance; a real exit and one reason lower the threat.
- 3. C. An early "I'm busy" in a rushed voice is usually a reflex; one calm pivot with a real choice is allowed, while pushing or discounting raises resistance.
- 4. B. Listeners read confidence from steadiness and fluency, not from slowness; rising pitch at every sentence sounds like asking permission.

- 5. D. It offers a genuine choice with a date; A and B are yes/no closes, and C names no date, person or action.

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